



NIPSA

STUDY SKILLS GUIDE

Study smarter. Learn deeper. Perform better...

**DEPARTMENT OF PHARMACOLOGY
UNIVERSITY OF ILES**

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01

START HERE

The Biology of Forgetting vs. The Science of Active Recall

The Illusion of Competence (Why Reading is Not Learning)

Many university students default to rereading lecture slides, underlining textbooks, and highlighting text. While these methods make you feel fast and productive, cognitive science reveals they create an **illusion of competence**.

When you reread text that is open right in front of you, your brain experiences a strong sense of *familiarity*. You mistake this visual recognition for actual structural mastery. However, recognition is passive; it relies completely on external cues. True academic performance requires **retrieval**: the independent ability to locate, extract, and deploy information when the source document is completely missing.

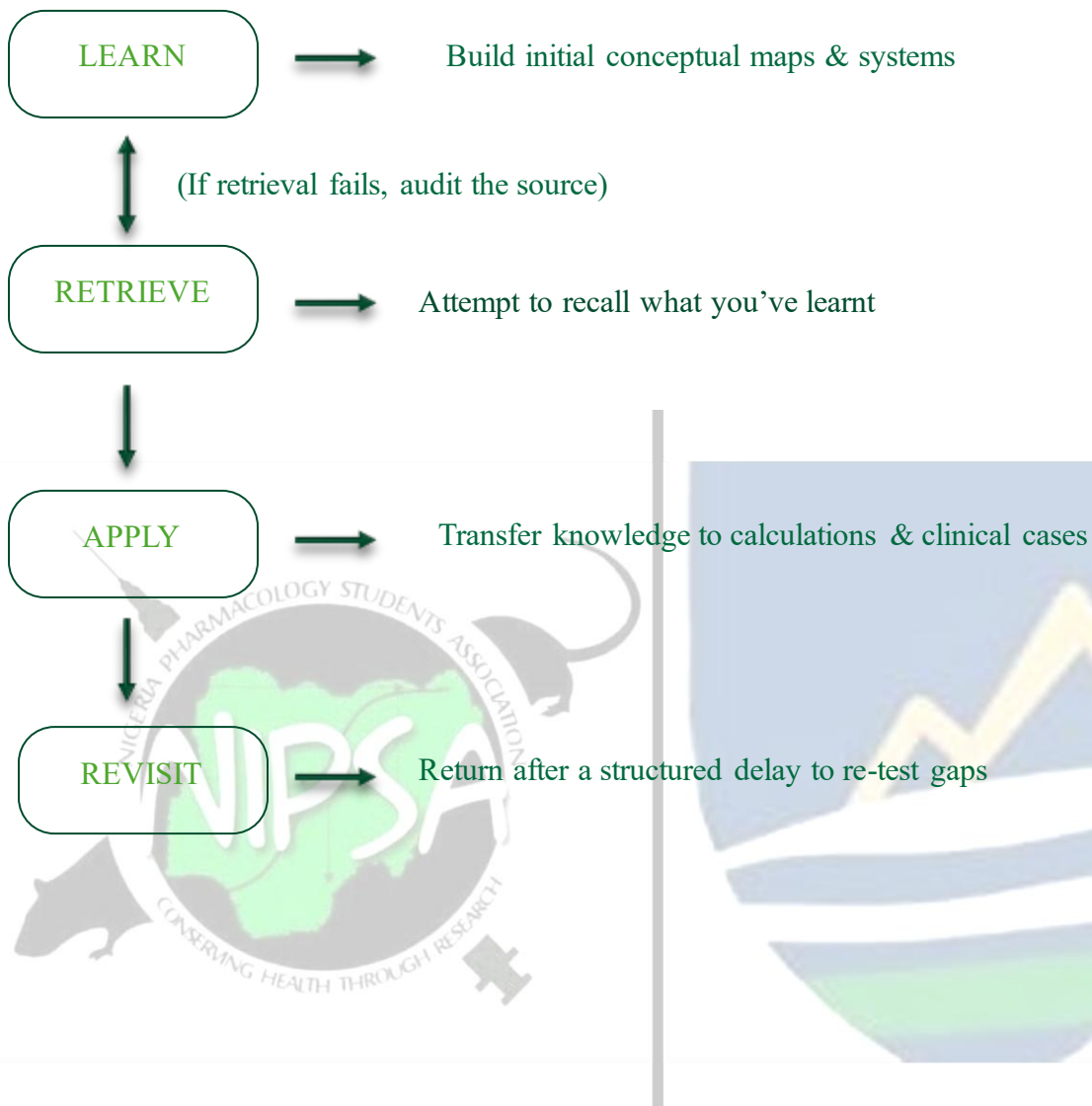
Passive Rereading (The Illusion) —>	Visual Recognition —>	Fails Under Exam Stress Active
Retrieval (The Reality) —>	Neural Pathway Construction —>	Independent Performance

The Learning Loop

To move past passive familiarity, your study routine must be structured as a continuous loop of mental effort. The Learning Loop divides study into four clear phases:

NOTE:

Do not introduce random difficulty; only interleave material that is meaningfully related and for which you already have a baseline understanding.





02

LEARN

How Effective Learning Works.

Learning becomes stronger when you repeatedly retrieve information and connect it to what you already know. The following techniques can be used across Pharmacology and the other courses you encounter at university.

Active Recall

Close your notes and explain a topic from memory. Use flashcards, short-answer questions, labelling tasks, or verbal explanations.

Try it with: Useful for drug classes, mechanisms, anatomy structures, physiology processes, definitions and terminology.

Spaced Repetition

Review material at increasing intervals instead of trying to relearn everything immediately before an examination.

Try it with: Useful for pharmacology, anatomy, physiology, medical terminology, formulas and other memory-heavy material.

Retrieval Practice

Test yourself regularly. Attempt questions, write what you remember, derive formulas, explain mechanisms or teach a concept before checking the answer.

Try it with: Works across nearly every course because it exposes gaps in recall.

Deep Learning

Ask why and how. Connect new information to previous knowledge and apply concepts to unfamiliar examples rather than memorising isolated statements.

Try it with: Especially useful when you need to explain mechanisms, interpret cases or transfer knowledge to new problems.



QUICK CHECK

After studying a topic, put your notes away and answer three questions: What do I remember? What can I explain? What can I apply?





03

BUILD

Build A Study System That Works.

A study system should make it easier to study consistently. It should fit your timetable, course load and personal constraints rather than copying someone else's routine.

Plan your week

- Set specific daily study goals instead of vague intentions such as “read today.”
- Schedule difficult or unfamiliar topics when you are most alert and least distracted.
- Record assignment deadlines, tests, practical and examination dates in one place.
- Leave buffer time for unexpected academic tasks instead of planning every minute.

Use focused sessions

- Choose one clear task for each session.
- Keep your phone and unnecessary browser tabs away when they are not needed.
- Take short breaks between focused sessions.
- Stop a session when concentration has clearly deteriorated; recovery is part of productivity.

TIP

Four focused hours spread across a week can be more useful than one exhausting marathon session. Consistency matters.



04

CAPTURE

Take Notes That Help You Learn.

Good notes are not a transcript of the lecturer. They are a tool for understanding, questioning and later retrieval.

Cornell Method

Divide the page into notes, cue questions/keywords and a short summary. Use the cue column later for self-testing.

Outline Method

Organize ideas using headings, subheadings and indented points. Useful when a lecture follows a clear hierarchy.

Mind Mapping

Place the main concept at the center and connect related ideas visually. Useful for systems, pathways and relationships.

TRY THIS

After a lecture, spend a few minutes turning your notes into questions. Those questions become ready-made retrieval prompts for later revision.



05

REVISIT

Revision That Actually Works.

Revision is not starting from page one every time. It is reinforcing what you have learned before it becomes difficult to retrieve.

Same day	Review the key ideas and clarify anything that was unclear.
24 hours	Test yourself without looking at your notes.
One week	Retrieve the topic again and complete practice questions.
Before the exam	Target weak areas, practise under exam conditions and review errors.

- Use past questions to practice retrieval and identify recurring weaknesses.
- Explain difficult concepts aloud as if teaching another student.
- Keep an error list: record what you got wrong and why.
- Spend more revision time on weak areas than on material you already know well.



06

APPLY

Study By Course Type.

Different courses demand different kinds of practice. Start with the dominant task the course requires, then combine techniques where useful.

COURSE TYPE	PRIORITY	EXAMPLES
Memory-heavy	Active recall + spaced repetition	Pharmacology, Anatomy, Physiology, terminology
Calculation/problem-solving	Worked problems + retrieval	Mathematics, Physics, Chemistry calculations
Mechanism/concept-heavy	Explain + apply + compare	Pharmacology mechanisms, Biochemistry, Physiology
Practical/laboratory	Recall + visualisation + procedure practice	Laboratory methods, anatomy practicals, demonstrations
Language	Retrieval + production + repetition	French vocabulary, grammar and conversation



07

APPLY

Manage Procrastination and Burnout.

Productivity is not measured by the number of hours you remain at a desk. If concentration, sleep or recovery deteriorate, study quality usually follows.

Watch for warning signs

- Difficulty concentrating on material you normally understand
- Constant fatigue or persistent sleep loss
- Reading repeatedly without being able to explain what you read
- Avoiding tasks because they feel too large or unclear
- Loss of motivation despite having important work to complete

Reduce the risk

- Protect a consistent sleep routine as much as your schedule allows.
- Use short breaks during focused study sessions.
- Eat and hydrate adequately, especially during long study periods.
- Use movement or short walks to break prolonged sitting.
- Avoid comparing your study hours with another student's routine.
- Reserve some time for genuine rest each week.

REMEMBER

A sustainable study routine is one you can repeat. If a system repeatedly leaves you exhausted, change the system, not your definition of success.



08

ORGANIZE

A Simple Weekly Study Template.

Use this template as a starting point. Adjust the number and length of sessions to your timetable, workload and other responsibilities.

DAY	MAIN TARGET	RETRIEVAL	REVIEW
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

Daily session template

- Define your objective: “By the end of this session I will be able to...”
- Learn or review the material.
- Close the notes and retrieve what you remember.
- Apply it with questions, examples, calculations or explanations.
- Record one weakness to revisit later.



09

CHECK

Before You Move On.

Use this quick checklist at the end of a study week or before an examination. Confirm:

- ☐ I can explain the major concepts without relying entirely on my notes.
- ☐ I have tested myself rather than only rereading.
- ☐ I have revisited important material more than once.
- ☐ I have attempted relevant practice or past questions.
- ☐ I know which topics I still find difficult.
- ☐ I have a plan for revisiting those weak areas.
- ☐ My study routine leaves enough room for sleep and recovery.

REMINDER

No single study technique works perfectly for everyone. Experiment, measure what improves your understanding and retention, and keep the methods that consistently help you learn.



**LEARN IT.
RETRIEVE IT.
APPLY IT.
REVISIT IT.**

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